Prevalence Rates of Non-Communicable Diseases by Highest Educational Qualification

Considering the age structure of education in Sri Lanka, the following analysis was conducted by assuming 25 years as the average age at which most individuals complete their education.

Table 6.3.11 : Prevalence Rates for the Population Aged 25 and Over by Highest Educational Qualification, 2024

Highest Educational Attainment	Total Population	Diabetes	High Cholesterol	High Blood Pressure	Heart Disease	Kidney Disease	Thalassemia	Cancer	Stroke	Asthma	Epilepsy
Population aged 25 and over*	13,869,099	13.3	12.9	15.8	3.7	1.2	0.1	0.6	0.9	2.4	0.3
Never attended school	399,879	17.7	17.8	27.5	6.2	2.4	0.2	1.0	3.1	6.5	1.5
Studied/ Studying at the special school/special educational unit	17,104	8.0	6.0	6.8	1.9	0.6	0.2	0.2	1.1	1.6	3.6
Passed grade 1 - 5	1,721,103	20.1	20.9	28.7	6.9	2.7	0.1	1.0	2.2	5.4	0.6
Passed grade 6 - 8	1,655,351	18.3	18.3	23.1	5.9	2.0	0.1	0.9	1.5	3.6	0.5
Passed grade 9 - 10	3,385,486	12.1	11.7	13.7	3.3	1.0	0.1	0.6	0.7	2.2	0.3
G.C.E. (O/L) or equal	3,054,744	12.4	11.7	13.5	3.1	0.8	0.1	0.5	0.5	1.6	0.2
G.C.E. (A/L) or equal	2,677,005	9.7	8.9	10.0	2.0	0.5	0.1	0.4	0.3	0.9	0.1
Degree & above	958,427	7.4	6.5	7.0	1.3	0.3	0.0	0.2	0.2	0.6	0.1

*Excluding the roofless population

According to Table 6.3.11, as the level of education increases among the population aged 25 years and over in Sri Lanka, the prevalence of non-communicable diseases (NCDs) shows a declining trend. Accordingly, a higher prevalence of NCDs can be observed among individuals with lower levels of education. Although the overall prevalence rate of diabetes is 13.3 percent, it exceeds 20 percent among those who have completed only Grade 1 to Grade 5. A relatively high prevalence rate of high blood pressure (27.5%) is observed among individuals who have never attended school, whereas among those with a degree or higher level of education, the rate is as low as 7 percent. Similarly, the prevalence of high cholesterol exceeds 20 percent among individuals with primary education (Grade 1–5), while it declines to 6.5 percent among those with degree-level or higher education. The prevalence of kidney disease remains below 3 percent among individuals who have never attended school or completed only Grade 1–5, whereas among those with degree-level or higher education, it is as low as 0.3 percent. Furthermore, the prevalence rates of cancer and stroke also demonstrate a declining trend with increasing levels of education. Overall, the data indicate that as the level of education increases, the risk of experiencing non-communicable diseases gradually decreases.